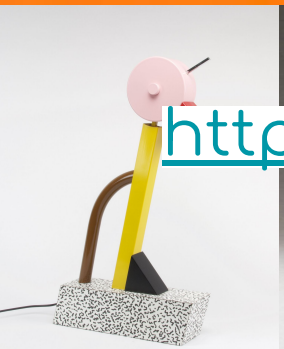


Memphis

Ettore Sottsass

1917 - 2007











https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0zVQ_SibpyM

ACTIVITY 1 - Starter: Record your thoughts… **SEE, THINK, WONDER**







"What common elements are we seeing?" and "Do these materials look 'expensive' or 'serious'?"

The **Memphis Group**, also known as Memphis Milano, was an Italian design and architecture group founded by Ettore Sottsass. It was active from **1980 to 1987**. The group designed postmodern furniture, lighting, fabrics, carpets, ceramics, glass and metal objects.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ekZ7PPrLrzg

(watch 2 minutes in and no longer than 27 minutes!)

Key Principles of Memphis

Memphis design principles reject minimalism for an exuberant and playful aesthetic, characterized by bold, often clashing colors, geometric shapes, asymmetrical forms, and patterns on patterns. Key characteristics also include the use of plastic laminate and terrazzo, a fondness for squiggles and kitsch motifs, and a rebellious challenge to conventional notions of good taste and functionalism to create objects with emotional value.

Key Design Principles

- **Rejection of Modernist Minimalism:** Memphis Design countered the sleek, minimalist trends that preceded it, embracing a bold and uninhibited style.
- **Exuberant Color Palette:** It uses bright, often clashing colors, including pink, yellow, blue, and later purple and teal, applied in unorthodox combinations.
- **Geometric Forms and Patterns:** Designs incorporate simple geometric shapes like triangles, squares, and circles, often arranged in bold, pattern-on-pattern compositions with stripes, dots, and abstract shapes.
- **Asymmetrical & Unconventional Forms:** A move away from traditional symmetry and conventional shapes, favoring asymmetry, and unusual forms to create a playful, almost naive quality.
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Key Principles on Memphis... continued

- **Playfulness & Whimsy:** The overall aesthetic is designed to be spirited, whimsical, and playful, encouraging creativity and challenging established design hierarchies.
- **Use of Plastic Laminate & Terrazzo:** These synthetic, modern materials are frequently used, selected for their synthetic and contemporary qualities.
- **Kitsch & Historical References:** The style incorporates elements of kitsch and sometimes alludes to historical styles in an arbitrary and postmodern way.
- **Emotional & Expressive Design:** Beyond functionality, Memphis Design aimed to provoke an emotional response and serve as a cultural and political expression, giving objects "emotional value





ACTIVITY 2: Ettore Sottsass - Valentine typewriter

"Does this look like the Memphis pieces we just saw?

What might have influenced this earlier work?"

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zhs151nkECw



ACTIVITY 2 - "Think-Pair-Share"

Task: Compare the Memphis piece with potential influence. Discuss and explain the visual connections.



'Bel Air' chair - by Peter Shire



kitsch









Pop Art





Art Deco

Activity 3: The Sottsass Method and Contemporary Relevance

Based on what you've observed and learned, how did Ettore Sottsass's 'method' challenge the design norms of his time?

Find one contemporary product (from the last 10 years) that you believe shows his influence and explain your reasoning.

Attach your image and reason to the google classroom assignment

Timed: 15 minutes